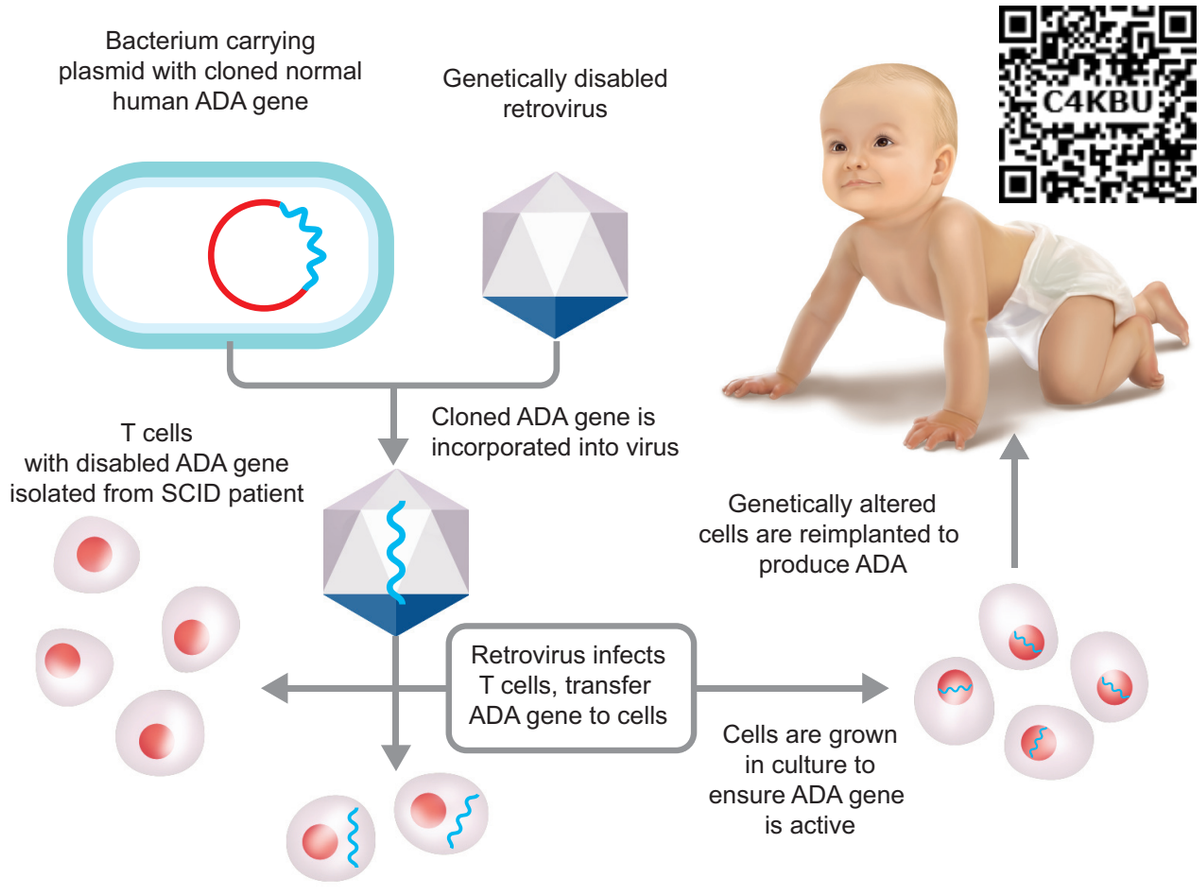


Fig. 10.3 Process of gene therapy

involves the introduction of DNA into germ cells which is passed on to the successive generations. Gene therapy involves isolation of a specific gene and making its copies and inserting them into target cells to make the desired proteins. It is absolutely essential for gene therapists to ensure that the gene is harmless to the patient and it is appropriately expressed and that the body's immune system does not react to the foreign proteins produced by the new genes.

10.3 Stem Cell Therapy

Stem cells are undifferentiated cells found in most of the multi cellular animals. These cells maintain their undifferentiated state even after undergoing numerous mitotic divisions.

Stem cell research has the potential to revolutionize the future of medicine with the ability to regenerate damaged and diseased organs. Stem cells are capable of self renewal and exhibit 'cellular potency'. Stem cells can differentiate into all types of cells that are derived from any of the three germ layers ectoderm, endoderm and mesoderm.

In mammals there are two main types of stem cells – Embryonic Stem Cells (ES Cells) and adult stem cells. ES Cells are both pluripotent (can produce the three primary germ layers ectoderm, mesoderm and endoderm) and multipotent (can differentiate into a number of types of cells) **(Fig. 10.4)**. ES cells are isolated from the epiblast tissue of the inner cell mass of a blastocyst. When stimulated, ES Cells can develop into more than 200 cells types of the adult body. ES Cells are immortal i.e., they can proliferate in a sterile culture medium and maintain their undifferentiated state.

Adult stem cells are found in various tissues of children as well as adults. An adult stem cell or somatic stem cell can divide and create another cell similar to it. Most of the adult stem cells are

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